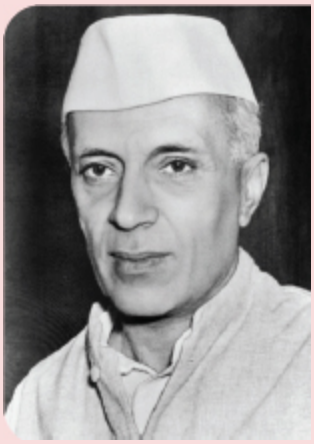


“Nothing is more advantageous than a rich heritage but nothing is more dangerous than to sit back and live on that heritage. A nation cannot prosper if it merely imitates its ancestors. What builds a nation is creative, inventive and vital activity.”

Jawaharlal Nehru, 1950

Many of the dance forms, musical styles and crafts that are studied, performed and produced across the subcontinent have existed for hundreds of years. After 1947, it was one of the priorities of the new nation to build institutions to encourage the preservation of these aspects of Indian culture, as well as to educate both Indians and those outside India about the rich and varied cultural heritage of the country. Accordingly, the first few decades after Independence saw the founding of several national institutions for the promotion of the arts, such as the national academies for music, dance, drama and literature.